

Surface Texture

Communicating material through mark-making

Every surface has texture — smooth, rough, glossy, matte, porous, fibrous. Capturing texture convincingly in a drawing comes down to choosing the right marks, at the right scale, with the right distribution.

KEY CONCEPTS

Texture vs Pattern

Texture is about the physical quality of a surface (rough, smooth). Pattern is about visual repetition (stripes, dots). Textures in drawing are implied — you don't draw every grain of wood, but suggest enough that the brain fills in the rest.

Mark Types for Common Textures

Wood: parallel lines following the grain direction, irregular knots. Stone: random stippling and broken edges. Fabric: subtle parallel lines following the drape. Skin: minimal texture, focus on value. Hair: flowing parallel strokes in the growth direction.

Texture Perspective

Texture gets smaller and more compressed in the distance, just like anything else in perspective. The bricks in the foreground are large; in the background, they're implied by tiny marks or faint lines. Inconsistent texture scale breaks the perspective illusion.

Selective Texture

Don't render texture everywhere equally. Emphasize texture at the focal point; simplify or eliminate it toward the edges. This guides the eye and prevents the drawing from feeling busy and overworked.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Create a texture library: 8 different surfaces, each in a 2×2 inch box.
2. Draw a still life with 3 different surface textures (ceramic, wood, fabric).
3. Draw the same surface twice: once close up (large texture marks), once far away (small or implied).